



SixthSense technology, invented by Indian computer scientist Pranav Mistry, at work
(Credit: <http://business.rediff.com>)

device connected to the cellphone of the customer.

This technology enables shoppers in retail outlets to communicate with the packaging of the products kept on shelves. Usually, while shopping for a big-ticket item, such as a high-end notebook or car, customers refer to sites that provide product reviews, comparisons between closely-competing products, etc.

However, such homework is generally not done for low-value items such as books, music, CDs, etc, as these are bought more impulsively. Using Sixth Sense technology, all a shopper needs to do is scan the product bar code and a lot of product-related information such as reviews, comparisons and the like is projected on any chosen surface.

This also allows retail outlets to save a lot of inventory space (and money) by stocking only one or few samples of different products and offer next day delivery—in case customers choose and buy the product via barcode scanning using a cellphone. This technology gives rise to creative convenience—imagine, the barcode on a box of tissue paper flashing a green light on scanning to denote eco-friendliness.

Augmented reality

AR adds a visual layer of information on top of such surfaces as a mirror, and the content interacts with layers of information provided by the real world. It is an increasingly popular technology wherein advancements are happening at a rapid pace. For example, by hold-

ing up a specially-coded box or label to a webcam-equipped computer, a user can see an augmented, 3D image of the product, or a graphic display of other additional information. Intel has developed a high-tech mirror that enables a shopper to see how the chosen clothes would look on him or her.

It is a digital trial room where the customer just needs to stand in front of an LCD monitor, and parametric technology simulates body type and displays how garments fit, based on weight, height and other measurements.

Malls of the future could use digital signage that delivers targeted advertising and also captures key customer demographic information via video for analysis later, thus creating almost-real-time customer feedback.

Major consumer product companies are also testing the business value of mobile mashups. Bionic Eye is an iPhone app wherein the user can point the camera at a mall to get a screen display of all outlets inside the building. Virtual signposts with directions to nearby points of interest are also included. And all this works offline.

Data mining and predictive analytics

You push your cart full of goodies to the cash register at the department store. Bar code of each product is transmitted one by one to the computer and all transactional data is saved in your folder. You have been assigned a customer ID number and asked to fill



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Plot No. EL-1, MIDC Electronic Zone,
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Tel : 0091-22-2767 3300 (Board), 2767 3311-16 (Sales)
Fax : 0091-22-27673310
Email : sales@mecoinstrument.com Web : www.mecoinstrument.com
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